

Progress report on the regional strategy for fostering digital health in the Eastern Mediterranean Region (2023–2027)

Introduction

1. At its 69th session in October 2022, the WHO Regional Committee for the Eastern Mediterranean adopted resolution EM/RC69/R.6, endorsing the regional strategy for fostering digital health in the Eastern Mediterranean Region (2023–2027) and its action plan, to guide Member States towards advancing digital transformation, knowledge translation and innovation.
2. The regional strategy aims to improve health outcomes in the Region through sustainable standards-based infrastructure and solutions aligned with national digital health priorities. Digital health services should be accessible, affordable, scalable, people-centred and based on country needs. This vision is advanced through four strategic objectives: (i) strengthening digital health governance, norms and standards at regional, national and subnational levels (as applicable to each country); (ii) advocating for digital health systems and networks that are people-centred, based on regional and national analysis, and supported and enabled by digital technologies, services and applications; (iii) advancing the development, implementation and evaluation of national digital health strategies, consistent with digital health maturity and linked to advancing national capacities and digital health literacy; and (iv) promoting regional and national stakeholder collaboration towards advancing digital transformation, knowledge translation and innovation.
3. Resolution EM/RC69/R.6 also requested the Regional Director, inter alia, to report on progress made in implementing the strategy to the 71st and 73rd sessions of the Regional Committee, and present a final report to the 75th session in 2028. This report summarizes the progress achieved by Member States with WHO support since October 2024. It should be read in conjunction with the progress report on the enhancement and digitalization of health information systems in the countries of the Eastern Mediterranean Region: a regional strategy, 2024–2028 (EM/RC73/INF.DOC.16).

Progress update

Strengthening digital health governance, norms and standards at regional, national and subnational levels (as applicable to each country)

4. The WHO *Digital health action plan for the Eastern Mediterranean Region, 2024–2028* was launched in 2025, reinforcing WHO's mandate to support countries through a clear, endorsed regional roadmap. The plan aims to accelerate the adoption of digital health technologies and improve health outcomes across the Region.
5. WHO conducted a survey in 2025 to assess the progress and challenges of telehealth and mHealth across the Region. The survey provided a regional overview of national efforts to use telehealth and mobile health (mHealth) to strengthen health systems and advance universal health coverage amid the Region's unique challenges. The findings on the adoption, governance and use of telehealth and mHealth identify critical gaps and enabling factors, while highlighting good practices.

6. At the country level, the Islamic Republic of Iran has elevated digital health to one of the Ministry of Health and Medical Education's top 10 priorities, marking a significant shift towards more structured and accountable digital health, as reflected in its inclusion in the 7th Five-Year Development Plan (2024–2028). Iraq has advanced alignment between the federal and Kurdistan regional health ministries to support interoperability and harmonized reporting standards, with WHO-supported digital health assessments and roadmap discussions contributing to a progressively unified national digital health architecture. Libya has reported the establishment of a high-level committee, chaired by the Minister of Health, to lead a sector-wide digitalization framework and roadmap.

Advocating for people-centred digital health systems and networks that are people-centred, based on regional and national analysis, and supported and enabled by digital technologies, services and applications

7. Notable advancements in people-centred digital health have emerged across the Region. Egypt, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates are pioneering large-scale virtual hospitals, reflecting a regional drive to strengthen the innovation ecosystem and address pressing health challenges. Oman has advanced its digital health transformation by integrating artificial intelligence (AI) into national screening programmes, expanding digital health insurance platforms and implementing interoperable medical imaging systems across referral hospitals, all aligned with the strategic goals of Oman Vision 2040. Qatar supports high-profile platforms such as the World Innovation Summit for Health and emphasizes research-driven precision medicine in its national strategy. Saudi Arabia fosters innovation through centres within its Ministry of Health, including initiatives such as the Regulatory Healthcare Sandbox programme to pilot digital health and AI solutions. Sudan is using digital health innovation approaches to scale up telemedicine solutions for gender-based violence and mental health and to improve referral systems.

8. In emergency-prone countries such as Afghanistan, Somalia, the Syrian Arab Republic and Yemen, digital health has become essential for sustaining care, enabling disease surveillance and coordinating the humanitarian response amid conflict and fragility.

9. The WHO Regional Office for the Eastern Mediterranean participated in WHO's flagship LEAD (Leap, Engage, Accelerate, Disrupt) initiative, designed to engage WHO staff, Member States and partners in generating and developing solutions to public health challenges.

Advancing the development, implementation and evaluation of national digital health strategies, consistent with digital health maturity and linked to advancing national capacities and digital health literacy

10. Since 2024, WHO has provided technical support to several Member States for developing and finalizing national digital health strategies, marking significant progress towards institutionalizing digital transformation across the Region. Egypt launched its National Digital Health Strategy 2025–2029 in November 2025 during the Global Congress on Population, Health and Human Development. The strategy outlines a roadmap to build an integrated, people-centred digital health system, unifying national health data, and to ensure safe, equitable access to high-quality services. Iraq's strategy accelerates universal health coverage by ensuring equitable access to reliable health information and high-quality services. Jordan's forthcoming strategy emphasizes governance, people-centred solutions, infrastructure strengthening and AI-driven innovations. Lebanon's 2025–2030 strategy focuses on people-centred care, workforce digital skills, interoperable standards, digitized logistics, streamlined licensing and integrated electronic health records. Morocco has prioritized digital health within its health system reform, using foundational white papers and institutional research to guide strategy development. Pakistan has developed a costed national

digital health framework for 2022–2030 that was approved by the Inter-ministerial Health and Population Council, marking a critical milestone for national governance.

Promoting regional and national stakeholder collaboration towards advancing digital transformation, knowledge translation and innovation

11. Multi-stakeholder collaboration continues to drive digital health progress across the Region, with WHO playing a central convening and coordinating role.

12. The Islamic Republic of Iran has secured high-level political support and sustainable financing from the parliament, government and judiciary, with all digital health grants funded through government mechanisms. In Iraq, WHO has played a key convening role, aligning digital health investments across the Ministry of Health, the United Nations Children’s Fund (UNICEF), the United Nations Population Fund, the International Organization for Migration and other partners within a coordinated national framework. In Palestine, ongoing digitalization efforts are supported through funding from the Government of Norway. Strengthened collaboration between the Ministry of Health, WHO and key stakeholders, including the World Bank Group and UNICEF, has aligned ongoing initiatives and ensured coordinated, effective implementation.

13. To amplify collective impact and advance regional digital transformation, the WHO Regional Office has formalized key strategic partnerships and actively engaged in advancing the establishment of designated WHO Collaborating Centres for digital health in the Region. This initiative aims to forge formal, long-term partnerships with leading academic and research institutions.

14. Regional capacity-building initiatives have included the launch of a WHO Academy course on planning national digital health systems. This multi-modal course and training programmes is designed to equip ministry of health leaders with technical concepts and tools to create comprehensive digital health strategies and strong governance structures. Eighteen participants from the Region’s francophone countries attended, including from Djibouti, Lebanon, Morocco and Tunisia. Additionally, a specialized certification programme was delivered for 60 heart health clinicians, in partnership with the American Heart Association and the University of North Carolina’s Center for Virtual Care Value and Excellence.

15. To ensure regional visibility and engagement, the WHO Regional Office, in collaboration with Member States, actively participated in the Second Global Convening of the Global Initiative on Digital Health in July 2025 and the Global Digital Health Forum in November 2025.

16. To harmonize global digital health efforts and amplify impact, WHO has initiated and facilitated structured regional collaboration. A joint webinar on digital health was held in May 2025 with the Regional Office for the Americas, attracting more than 200 virtual participants. A seven-part webinar series was organized with the Regional Office for Africa during September–December 2025 for digital health focal persons across both regions, engaging approximately 60 participants virtually.

Challenges

17. While more than half of countries in the Eastern Mediterranean Region have a national digital health strategy or roadmap for digital health, significant gaps persist in translating these high-level plans into subnationally funded, implemented and scaled programmes. Barriers include fragmented governance (multiple ministries with their own mandates), lack of dedicated budget lines and challenges in integrating digital tools into routine clinical workflows.

18. A significant proportion of the population in the Region lacks access to reliable Internet connectivity and smart devices, limiting their ability to use digital health services.

19. The dual digital literacy gap among health workers and the public critically undermines equitable progress. Insufficient workforce training stalls the adoption of digital health technologies and impacts data quality, while populations in vulnerable settings lack the skills and trust to access digital services, widening the digital access divide. This foundational challenge limits both current impact and future innovation at scale.

20. The rapid, unstructured introduction of AI-powered diagnostic tools, health chatbots and algorithmic systems has outpaced the development of national regulatory and ethical guidelines, raising concerns about the safety, efficacy, bias and data privacy implications of these technologies, with most countries lacking a dedicated governance framework for AI in health.

The way forward

21. The Eastern Mediterranean Region continues to face significant health challenges, including protracted emergencies, health workforce shortages and disparities in service delivery. Digital health remains a critical enabler for overcoming these barriers, enhancing system resilience and ensuring equitable, people-centred health services.

22. Significant progress was achieved during 2024–2026 in advancing the digital health agenda in the Region, guided by the regional strategy and action plan. Member States have strengthened policies, expanded services and fostered innovation, with more countries now developing national digital health strategies and roadmaps.

23. WHO will continue to support the operationalization of these strategies, focusing on investment plans, interoperability standards and monitoring frameworks. Continued commitment, investment and partnership will be essential to ensure that digital health meaningfully contributes to health equity, system resilience, and progress towards universal health coverage and the health-related Sustainable Development Goals.

24. WHO will focus its strategic support on four interconnected frontier domains: AI, innovation, cybersecurity and telemedicine. While momentum is building rapidly across the Region, these fields require robust frameworks to ensure their impact and sustainability. There is a profound, concurrent need for rigorous impact evaluations, documented use cases, and stronger governance and regulatory structures.

25. WHO is working to foster regional collaboration by sharing best practices, co-developing solutions, and advocating for targeted investments and capacity-building aligned with United Nations interagency coordination and regional mechanisms, such as the Regional Health Alliance and the World Summit on the Information Society, as well as national coordination platforms, to ensure support aligns with country priorities and avoids duplication of effort.

26. The WHO side-event on AI for health, scheduled to take place during the 73rd session of the Regional Committee, aims to provide practical insights on the policy and regulatory frameworks for strengthening AI governance and creating a foundational ecosystem for its implementation. The event also aims to foster partnerships across the health, academic and telecommunications sectors to support the responsible integration of AI into the Region's health systems, and thus serves as a critical step towards the formation of a regional technical advisory group on AI.